Kennedy was asking Congress for authorization to call up 150,000 reservists if the need arose. For Khrushchev, obsessed with the prospect of an American invasion of Cuba, that could mean only one thing—the Americans were coming. By now he had all but run out of his nuclear ammunition, sending to Cuba almost every type of nuclear weapon in his possession. What was left was the power of bluster, which Khrushchev had in unlimited quantity.

To Kennedy's terse statement of September 5, Khrushchev responded with his own on September 11. It was more than ten times as long as Kennedy's: 4,600 words to Kennedy's 377. Khrushchev used the statement to declare that in response to Kennedy's decision to ask for a possible mobilization of reserves, he was putting his own troops on high alert.

Khrushchev claimed that while there were indeed Soviet military instructors on Cuba, they were fewer in number than the civilian advisers sent to the island. He was lying. He was also bluffing: "Our nuclear weapons are so powerful in their explosive force, and the Soviet Union has such powerful rockets to carry these nuclear warheads, that there is no need to search for sites for them beyond the boundaries of the Soviet Union." To the whole world that sounded like an assurance, if not a guarantee, that Khrushchev was not sending nuclear weapons to Cuba. At the same time he warned Washington against invading Cuba: "[O]ne cannot now attack Cuba and expect that the aggressor will be free from punishment for this attack. If this attack is made, this will be the beginning of the unleashing of war." He had in mind "a universal world war with the use of thermonuclear weapons."[14]

Kennedy refused to answer Khrushchev with a statement of his own, and on September 28, Khrushchev fired off one of his longest letters yet. Totaling close to 4,500 words, it was almost as long as the TASS statement of September 11 on Cuba. The immediate trigger was the resolution, passed by Congress on September 20, giving Kennedy a free hand to invade Cuba. Once again Khrushchev threatened nuclear war. He complained bitterly about American ships following and harassing Soviet vessels on their way to Cuba: "I said then and I repeat—let them try to stop and sink our ships—this will be the beginning of war because we will answer in kind." He also